

DISCOVERY

QUESTION GUIDE

A practical guide for your conversation with Mastercard.

THE GOAL

Understand the customer before you design the solution.

Use these questions as prompts - not a script. Follow the conversation, listen carefully, and go deeper when you hear something important.

ASK

Open questions

LISTEN

For evidence

FOLLOW UP

On signals

VALIDATE

What you heard

You do not need to ask every question.

The best discovery conversations feel natural, not rehearsed.

Start with context

First understand the person, their role, and how the work happens today.

01

Tell us about your role and how you are involved in this process.

Helps you understand the stakeholder's perspective and responsibilities.

02

Who else is involved from beginning to end?

Reveals handoffs, dependencies, and other people affected by the process.

03

Can you walk us through how this works today?

Builds a shared picture of the current state before discussing improvements.

04

What tools, systems, or information do you rely on?

Surfaces the environment your eventual solution may need to work within.

05

Which parts of the process require the most attention from your team?

Helps identify where effort and complexity concentrate.

06

What happens before this process begins - and what happens after?

Expands the view so your team does not solve only one isolated step.

Find the friction

Now explore where the experience becomes slow, manual, inconsistent, risky, or frustrating.

07

What is the most difficult part of this process today?

Invites the customer to prioritize the pain in their own words.

08

Where do delays or bottlenecks usually happen?

Looks for moments where work stops, waits, or requires escalation.

09

Which tasks feel repetitive or unnecessarily manual?

Surfaces potential opportunities without assuming automation is the answer.

10

Where do mistakes, rework, or inconsistencies tend to appear?

Helps identify quality and reliability problems.

11

Are there any workarounds your team uses to get the job done?

Workarounds are often strong signals that the current process is not meeting the need.

12

What part of this experience would you change first if you could?

Forces prioritization and reveals what matters most to the stakeholder.

Understand the impact

A problem becomes meaningful when you understand what it affects and why it matters.

13

Who is most affected when this problem happens?

Identifies the users, teams, or customers who experience the consequences.

14

What happens because of this issue?

Moves the conversation from the symptom to its business or human impact.

15

How often does this happen?

Adds context about frequency and whether the problem is occasional or systemic.

16

Does this affect time, quality, cost, risk, or customer experience? How?

Helps translate pain into outcomes your team can reason about.

17

Can you share a recent example of when this happened?

Specific examples are stronger evidence than general statements.

18

What happens if nothing changes?

Clarifies urgency and the consequence of maintaining the current state.

Explore constraints + success

A strong solution must fit the customer's reality - and improve an outcome they actually value.

CONSTRAINT

What information or data is needed for this process?

Data availability can shape what is realistic.

SUCCESS

If this worked significantly better, what would change?

Defines the desired future state in customer language.

CONSTRAINT

Are there security, privacy, compliance, or access considerations we should understand?

Important constraints should be discovered before building.

SUCCESS

How would you know the improvement was successful?

Surfaces useful measures or observable outcomes.

CONSTRAINT

Are there systems or teams this process depends on?

Reveals integrations and organizational dependencies.

SUCCESS

If you could solve only one part, which would create the most value?

Helps the team prioritize before Strategize.

A GREAT FINAL QUESTION

“What haven't we asked that you think we should understand?”

Follow-up toolkit

The first answer is often only the beginning. Use follow-ups to uncover context and evidence.

GO DEEPER

→ Can you tell me more about that?

→ Why does that happen?

GET AN EXAMPLE

→ Can you give us a recent example?

→ What happened next?

UNDERSTAND PEOPLE

→ Who experiences that most often?

→ Who else is affected?

MEASURE IT

→ How often does this happen?

→ How much time or effort does it require?

VALIDATE

→ So, if we understood correctly...

→ Is that the main issue, or is there something deeper?

EXPLORE SUCCESS

→ What would better look like?

→ What would become easier if this were solved?

TIP

When you hear a strong signal, stay with it. Do not rush back to your prepared list.

Questions to avoid

Avoid wording that leads the customer, assumes the solution, or produces only a yes/no answer.

AVOID

Would an AI agent solve this?

TRY

What would an ideal outcome look like?

AVOID

Don't you think this takes too long?

TRY

How much time does this typically require?

AVOID

Would automation make this easier?

TRY

Which parts require the most manual effort?

AVOID

Is this the biggest problem?

TRY

Which challenge has the greatest impact, and why?

REMEMBER

Your questions should help the customer explain their reality - not confirm your idea.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Capture the signal.

Your notes should give your team enough evidence to move into Strategize.

WHO Who experiences the problem?

WHAT What is happening today?

FRICTION What specific pain did you hear?

IMPACT Why does it matter?

EVIDENCE What example or signal supports it?

CONSTRAINTS What must a solution respect?

SUCCESS What would a better outcome look like?

NEXT

Use your Discovery Notes to synthesize what you heard.

Then move into 02 / STRATEGIZE.